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RDB 242/6

RESEARCH AND DEVELOPMENT BOARD
Washington 25, D. C.

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19 May 1953

Copy No. 12

MEMORANDUM FOR ASSISTANT CHIEF OF STAFF, G-2
Department of the Army
DEPUTY CHIEF OF NAVAL OPERATIONS (Operations)
Attn: Director, Naval Intelligence Division
Department of the Navy
DEPUTY CHIEF OF STAFF, OPERATIONS
Attn: Director of Intelligence
Department of the Air Force

SUBJECT: Guidance for Research on Interrogation Techniques and Agents, and Interrogation Countermeasures

Reference: JCS, JIC Memo for Chrmn RDB, JIC-163-53 of 12 May 1953 (S)

Attachment: RDB 242/1, Report of Ad Hoc Medical Study Group [redacted] dated 15 January 1953 (S) - 2 copies

1. I activated an ad hoc study group in August 1952 to determine whether a potential threat exists to National Security by ascertaining whether effective and practical techniques exist, or could be developed, which could be utilized to render an individual subservient to an imposed will or control. Complete effectiveness of such techniques was understood to mean that the individual exposed would be subsequently unaware of their use. The code word [redacted] (Restricted) was assigned to the operations of the study group.

2. The group completed its preliminary study and submitted the attached report, RDB 242/1, in January 1953. The report indicated all known techniques and agents which may be applicable to the problem and contained comments on the feasibility of utilizing them and of protecting against them. Comments on the existing military research and development program in this area and recommendations relative to promising research were also included.

3. It appeared that research along the lines indicated by the report may contribute to the attainment of an interrogation potential not apparent to date and would provide means for indoctrination and protection against any such developments by the USSR. Inasmuch as we were not aware of any requirements for research of this nature, I asked the Joint Intelligence Committee to advise me of any such requirements. By reference memorandum,

[redacted]

[redacted]

I was advised that an urgent need exists, from an intelligence and security point of view, to develop effective and practical techniques, which, if utilized, would render an individual subservient to an imposed will or control. The JIC also stated that attention should be directed in research to the possibility of employing effective techniques which could nullify in advance any attempt to impose a will or control for the purpose of extracting classified information. Further research as to the physiological effect of drugs and chemicals on human beings was indicated as justified. The JIC also stated its continuing interest in the broader field of the effect of drugs and chemicals on human beings as related to interrogation techniques and countermeasures from an intelligence point of view.

4. The attached report contains research recommendations relative to immediate military needs and the collection of data which may improve basic understanding and thus ultimately prove to be of military use. These recommendations point out desirable research, the need for which is confirmed by the JIC statements.

5. I am forwarding the report to you for your information, guidance and appropriate action. We would be pleased to work with you on any further research and development planning which may be desirable and to reconvene our study group to assist in such studies, if necessary.

6. It is requested that you keep the RDB advised of your research and development activities in the field of interrogation techniques and agents and in interrogation countermeasures. Our activities in this field are handled by [redacted], Vice Chairman, and [redacted] of his staff.

[redacted]

Chairman

cc: Army G-4 w/o attachment
Navy CNO (Attn: Op-372) w/o attachment
AF DCS/D w/o attachment
Chrmn, JIC, JCS w/o attachment

[redacted]